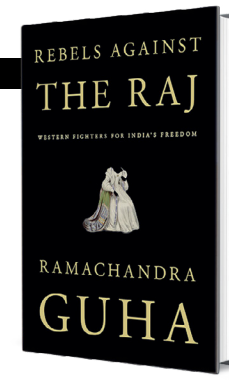
2022 BOOKS IN REVIEW

It was a tumultuous year in Indian publishing but readers were spoilt for choice



REBELS AGAINST THE RAJ: Western Fighters for India's Freedom *by Ramachandra Guha*

South Asian fiction made a big splash at international awards this year—scooping up two Bookers and a raft of praise. Sri Lanka's Shehan Karunatilaka won fiction's top prize for *The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida*, a black comedy set in the afterlife, while Geetanjali Shree won the International Booker for her Partition-themed Hindi novel *Tomb of Sand*.

However, Shree, who was also shortlisted for India's top honour—the Rs 25 lakh JCB Prize—lost to Urdu writer Khaled Jawed. His winning novel, *The Paradise of Food*, tracked a Muslim middle-class family over half a century and was hailed by the jury as a "modern fable" and "fine artistic achievement". It was the third year in a row that the prize went to a translated work—the shortlist consisted entirely of translations.

Tumult beset the Indian literary firmament early in the year. In February, Westland, among India's most-respected publishers, was shut down, following a decision from its owner Amazon. It had published popular fiction writers (Amish Tripathi, Anuja Chauhan), literary stars (Perumal Murugan) and respected journalists (Josy Joseph). But in April, Westland announced a return in partnership with Pratilipi, an Indian digital storytelling platform.

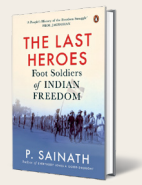
Indian non-fiction continued to go from strength to strength. Notable works included journalist Mansi Choksi's reportage on love and marriage in India (*The Newlyweds*), doctor-professor Siddhartha Mukherjee's magisterial account of the body (*The Song of the Cell*) and banker Ravindra Rathee's military history of the British presence in India (*True to Their Salt*). Historian Ramachandra Guha returned with *Rebels Against the Raj*, stories of seven foreigners who took part in India's freedom struggle. Another people-driven treatment of that period emerged in P. Sainath's *The Last Heroes*, which traced the ordinary men and women who made up the ranks of the freedom fighters.

Beyond these, the biography as a form saw some impressive additions, particularly of writers. In the remarkable *Writer, Rebel, Soldier, Lover*, journalist Akshaya Mukul charted the life and times of Agyeya or Sachchidanand Hiranand Vatsyayan, the literary legend and Sahitya Akademi award winner. Nirmal Verma, another Hindi literary giant, was the subject of *Here and Hereafter*, an angular textual biography of the man and his work by Vineet Gill.

In the West, the year's big publishing event was the new work by Hanya Yanagihara, whose second novel *A Little Life* was both a smash hit and a polarising pop culture artefact. Her third, *To Paradise*, also a sprawling decades-spanning epic, saw mixed reviews, but brisk sales.

Two Pulitzer Prize winners had books out in 2022, and picked up where they left off. Jennifer Egan, whose mesmerising 2011 winner *A Visit from the Goon Squad* told interconnected stories, released *The Candy House*, a sequel that revisited some of the same characters, now older. Andrew Sean Greer, whose sizzling debut *Less* won in 2018, returned to the same world in *Less is Lost*, this time sending his central character Arthur Less on a road trip. 2015 Booker Prize winner Marlon James also brought us the second in his fantasy-fiction trilogy by way of *Moon Witch, Spider King*. ■

Bhavya Dore



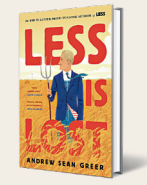
THE LAST HEROES *by P. Sainath*



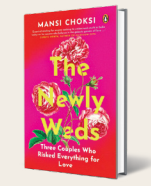
THE CANDY HOUSE *by Jennifer Egan*



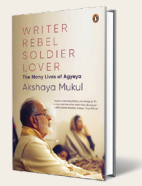
TRUE TO THEIR SALT *by Ravindra Rathee*



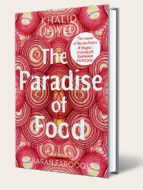
LESS IS LOST *by Andrew Sean Greer*



THE NEWLY-WEDS *by Mansi Choksi*



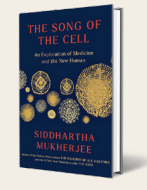
WRITER, REBEL, SOLDIER, LOVER *by Akshaya Mukul*



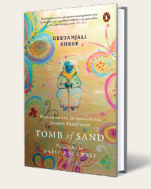
THE PARADISE OF FOOD *by Khalid Jawed*



THE SEVEN MOONS OF MAALI ALMEIDA *by Shehan Karunatilaka*



THE SONG OF THE CELL *by Siddhartha Mukherjee*



TOMB OF SAND *by Geetanjali Shree*